What to Notice and Write Down While Mom's Plan Takes Shape

Mail, bills, conversations and paperwork: fifteen everyday things to note, with no interpreting.

Letters, bills and phone calls about Mom's care arrive most days now, and it's hard to tell which details are worth keeping. This guide names fifteen everyday things to notice while her plan takes shape and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What any item means for Mom, for Medicaid or for her money is a question for a professional who knows her state and her situation, and the notes you keep are what make that conversation useful. The areas follow the planning step's own list: care, income, assets, transfers, documents and legal matters. The everyday tasks are the ones the federal Administration for Community Living lists, and the record-keeping advice follows AARP and the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau. The wording about what to write down is ours.

Mom's care

1 The help she gets each day [1]

NOTICE Which everyday tasks the staff help her with: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to and from a bed or chair, eating.

WRITE DOWN What you've seen and what staff have told you, with the date and who said it.

2 Changes in her care

NOTICE A move to a different room or unit, a therapy starting or stopping, a care meeting on the calendar.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and who told you.

3 The people you talk to

NOTICE Who at the facility answers which kind of question: the nurse, the social worker, the business office.

WRITE DOWN Each name, role and phone number, and what each has told you so far.

Bills and money coming in

4 The facility's monthly statement [2]

NOTICE The date, the period it covers, the lines on it, and anything new since last month.

WRITE DOWN The date, the total, which account paid it and who made the payment. Keep the statement.

5 Other costs for Mom [3]

NOTICE Pharmacy charges, supplies, the hairdresser at the facility, anything a family member pays for out of their own pocket.

WRITE DOWN The date, the amount and who paid. Keep the receipt, even a small one.

6 Money coming in [3]

NOTICE The deposits that arrive each month, such as Social Security or a pension, and any letter about them.

WRITE DOWN The source, how often it arrives and which account it lands in. Round amounts are fine.

Accounts, property and insurance

7 Statements in the mail or the inbox [3]

NOTICE Each bank, investment or retirement account that sends a statement, and whose name or names are on it.

WRITE DOWN The institution, the names on the account and where the statements are kept. Leave account numbers off your working page.

8 Insurance policies [2]

NOTICE A long-term care policy, a life insurance policy, a premium notice.

WRITE DOWN The company, the kind of policy, where the policy is, and whether anyone has called the company about it.

9 The house, the car and other property [2]

NOTICE A deed, a mortgage or home-equity statement, a property tax bill, a vehicle title.

WRITE DOWN What exists, whose name is on it and where the paper is.

Money or property that has changed hands

10 Gifts, sales and changes of name

NOTICE Anything of Mom's that the family remembers being given, sold or put in someone else's name, and anything like that a statement shows.

WRITE DOWN What it was, roughly when and who was involved, as plain facts. What it means, if anything, is a question for your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.

Legal papers

11 Papers that name someone to act for Mom [5] [4]

NOTICE A power of attorney, a health care power of attorney or a living will, wherever it turns up: a desk drawer, a safe-deposit box, an attorney's office.

WRITE DOWN Which papers exist, the date on each, who is named and where the original is. Reading them for what they allow is an attorney's job.

12 Requests for proof of authority [2]

NOTICE A bank, the facility or an agency asking who is allowed to act or sign for Mom.

WRITE DOWN Who asked, what they asked for and the date.

Mail, notices and what you've been told

13 Official mail

NOTICE Letters from Medicare, Social Security, the state Medicaid agency, an insurer or the facility: who sent it, the date on it, and any date it mentions.

WRITE DOWN The sender, the letter's date, any date it mentions and where you filed it. If you can't tell what it is asking, ask the sender or bring it to your Medicaid planner.

14 Advice as it arrives

NOTICE What the facility, a friend, a professional or a website said about paying for Mom's care.

WRITE DOWN What was said, who said it, the date, and whether that person knows Mom's situation. Mark where two pieces disagree, and leave it at that.

15 Papers someone asked for that you can't find [2]

NOTICE Any document a professional, the facility or an agency has asked for that hasn't turned up.

WRITE DOWN What it is, who asked and who in the family might have it.

When a note isn't enough

A few things on this list are a conversation as well as a note. A letter that asks for something goes to its sender or to your Medicaid planner. A request to sign something, or any thought of moving money or property, goes to an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional before anything is done; the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid. A change in how Mom is doing goes to the facility's nurse or her doctor.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean for Medicaid, for Mom's money or for her care, and it doesn't grade your family's situation. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. The professionals do the interpreting, and they do it better with your notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed and noted, without having to work out what any of it means. The planning interview is the next step: it asks about your family's situation, so your notes have somewhere to go, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. AARP, A Legal Checklist for Family Caregivers
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Legal Steps for Medical Well-being
5. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Considering a financial caregiver? Know your options